



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 41

SOUTH CAROLINA

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside South Carolina's family courts and child-welfare system.

42

SOUTH CAROLINA FAMILIES ON
RECORD · 61 CHILDREN IMPACTED ·
22 MONTHS MEDIAN MONTHS LOST
OF PARENTING TIME

REPORT GENERATED
APRIL 26, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
12 OF 46

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

SOUTH CAROLINA AT A GLANCE.

Across 42 South Carolina families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 61 42 of 42 families reported child counts	MEDIAN ATTORNEY FEES \$20,000 per reporting family	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 22 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 52.4% 50.0% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 42	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.5	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 42 of 42	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 12

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so South Carolina families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02

THE COST OF SOUTH CAROLINA FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	33	\$20,000	\$159,436	\$5,261,400
Lost Wages	22	\$20,000	\$136,773	\$3,009,000
Other Court Fees	17	\$2,000	\$6,862	\$116,650
Therapy / Evaluations	26	\$7,000	\$11,569	\$300,790
Reunification Services	17	\$1,000	\$8,124	\$138,100
GAL Fees	30	\$8,000	\$16,689	\$500,659
Asset Loss	17	\$100,000	\$351,176	\$5,970,000
Estimated Median Family Impact	—	\$158,000	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost		22	1.8 yrs
Mean months lost		29	2.4 yrs
Total across all families		632	52.7 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · SOUTH CAROLINA

Most families documenting in South Carolina are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Not provided		25	60%
Active case: stuck or delayed		15	36%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		1	2%
Case closed: within last 2 years		1	2%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and CPS		23	55%
Family Court Only		14	33%
Unknown		4	10%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		1	2%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		15	36%
3 – 5 years		10	24%
Over 10 years		5	12%
6 months – 1 year		4	10%
5 – 10 years		3	7%

CUSTODY STATUS

Visitation Only		15	36%
No Contact / Total Loss of Access		10	24%
50/50 Joint		6	14%
Full Custody		5	12%
Children in Foster Care		3	7%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Greenville		2	5%
Lexington		2	5%
Charleston		2	5%
United States		2	5%
Berkeley		2	5%
Horry		1	2%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		17	40%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		7	17%
Other: (Short answer)		6	14%
High Conflict Divorce		2	5%
I think my attorney and the court appointed GAL are close friends and they are all connected, the reunification therapist and the custody evaluator psychiatrist all connected to the GAL		2	5%

05 PARENT VOICES — SOUTH CAROLINA

Quotes appear as submitted. Long submissions are trimmed with [...] to fit the page; the full unedited quote is available in the online version of this report.



I rebuilt my life in 4 years from nothing when we left our abuser to 6 figure salary, purchased two homes, children had security, and I was healing and thriving. Alienation claims and a notoriously corrupt attorney have taken it all away to punish us but despite the gift of PTSD [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system took my children based on assumptions instead of facts, leaving us emotionally broken and fighting to be heard. No parent should lose time with their children because no one stopped to verify the truth.

— LAURA

This system has destroyed my family over false allegations and lies.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has taken my children, ripped children from their sister based on false allegations that were used knowing what the “temporary” order would entail, and almost 2 years later nothing has changed.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Destroyed my life and ruined my child.

— VIRGINIA

It drained me of EVERYTHING, money, hope, happiness, and very traumatizing.

— MONIQUE

It has destroyed me and my babies mentally, and emotionally. Cause finance damage, and causing struggle

— LAWANNA

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



“The system repeatedly fails the ones that need it most- innocent children by enabling abusers and adding more victims to their lists. In my case, it’s his second go around and it’s “pay to play” in SC family court as I sadly continue to hear,. Around here they follow the money [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Tormented my children and myself by enabling our abuser to the point of suicidal ideation in a 9 year old!

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Family court has attempted to viciously fracture my role as a mother and deteriorate my ability to provide as a newly single parent. Instead of helping us out of an abusive situation- it has acted as a method to harm us further with institutionalized and legal abuse.

— BRENNA

Allowed my exwife to remove me from my son’s life and replace me with her new husband. Years later she still emails my place of work claiming making false claims even after my rights were terminated.

— BRENT

On top of not being able to parent my son, after years of him being in our home, my step-children have been traumatized, and my wife has been beyond depressed. The harm inflicted upon my family is immeasurable.

— THOMAS

Completely restored not only hope in justice but teaching my son that bad behavior and lies gets rewarded

— EDEE

That have taken my child from me . I have narcissist and domestic violence.. He has a drinking problem, smoking MJ sex addiction

— JAYME

I don’t know where to even start it has been a total nightmare. My children and I have lost all hope that anyone will help them.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Family court gave my abuser custody of two of my children with no DNA proof of relation. The oldest of the two was not his but the court claimed phycological parent, the younger was never DNA tested even when I asked for it.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



The system took my child for two months for no reason, she got ahold of my straightener burnt her leg it healed fine went to 4 pediatric doctors, as well as an abuse doctor at the Julie Valentine Center, they refuse to give me the report from JVC and getting me for physical [...]

— BAILEY

They have torn my daughter from me 2 weeks after n her father died. Took her away from her brother. Broke our bond. Broke my heart. Ruined our lives!

— SHONNA

No proof given was defaulted got annulated

— ANDREW

The system has caused irreparable harm to my family. My youngest child atill hasn't dealt with the trauma she has experienced. She is terrified to be away from us now. Family court is a child trafficking ring and needs ABOLISHED!

— PETER

It has destroyed the relationship of a child, parent, and entire family. Caused medical issues such as a bipulmonary embolism. Fear of retaliation and inability to fight for or protect a child. I am speaking for my husband as he has been gagged due to my social media.

— NICOLE

The Charleston County Family Court system, aligned with a vindictive parent, tore apart our happy family, caused trauma beyond imagination, and made it hard to even get out of bed many mornings.

— KATE

I reported concerns my child raise of department of social services. Due to multiple reports being unfounded I've lost primary custody. My ex is military and deployed and the judge is leaving my child with the step mom. Despite never being notified and her not having [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has left us fighting for our peace and safety while being told I need to trust the man who has abused me for years and continues to use the courts to hurt me.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

We have lost so much time, and now my daughter does not want to see or speak to me

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



*Knowingly Prying on the bereaved., Using my already diagnosed mental health cause
More mental anguish mental distress mental harm to my family, soul bound*

— ROBIN

The system along with my cousin and drive away so deep
between me and my daughter that I don't know that it
could ever be fixed and they allowed that to happen

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Too much to write here.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Financially destroy me, a father who doesn't even want
his daughter just use her to destroy and hurt me, loss of
trust in the system, my daughter withdrawn and in
emotional distress at 6 years old

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Motivated me to expose it. All of it. Husband hid cameras
in my house- secretly recording me. Had to hire 5
lawyers. Family, case law, dss, wiretapping, criminal.
Women that don't have several hundred thousand dollars
to fall back on never see their kids and go to prison for
[...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

30 South Carolina parents submitted ranked quotes. 30 appear in this report; the remainder are available at standwithmeg.com/sc.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this South Carolina report comes from South Carolina respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in South Carolina — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 42 South Carolina families reporting here are not the universe of South Carolina families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – April 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte-Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 5 independent families name the same actor.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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